

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

B

Babel: The Dispersion of Nations

The story of the tower of Babel explains how language barriers separated nations and ethnic groups, scattering them geographically. After the great flood, when God judged a very evil human race, humans rebelled again by building a tower “that reaches to the heavens” ([Genesis 11:4](#)). Instead of worshiping God, they wanted to glorify themselves and unite without God. God saw their dangerous independence and pride that could lead them back to evil and destruction. So, God acted to “confuse their language,” and he “scattered them over the face of all the earth” ([11:7, 9](#)).

Babel marks the start of differences and misunderstandings between peoples and nations who cannot understand each other’s languages and cultures. This separation only begins to reverse with the coming of the Holy Spirit (see [Acts 2](#)).

After the nations scattered at Babel, God renewed His relationship with humanity through Abraham and his descendants ([Genesis 12:1–9](#)). Unlike the people at Babel, Abraham was righteous because he “believed the LORD.” He lived by faith in God, not pride in his achievements ([15:6; 17:1; 18:19; 26:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 11:1–9](#)

Baptism

Baptism has been a key part of Christianity since it began ([Acts 2:38](#)). In Judaism, “baptism” and “baptize” referred to a religious cleansing ceremony. The law of Moses required water to cleanse people from ceremonial impurity ([Numbers 19:14–19](#)).

Later, gentile (non-Jewish) converts to Judaism had to do certain things. These included studying the Torah, circumcision, and a ceremonial bath to remove spiritual impurities from their gentile past. This cleansing often took place in special baths called mikvahs. Many synagogues had mikvahs, and the temple in Jerusalem had many as well. This suggests that worshippers would ceremonially bathe before worship.

John the Baptizer preached “a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins” ([Luke 3:3](#)). John’s baptism helped spiritually prepare people to receive God’s chosen one, the Messiah ([Luke 3:4–6](#)). Those who received his baptism and repented were ready for Jesus’ message ([Luke 7:29–30](#)).

After his resurrection, Jesus told his disciples to baptize new Christian disciples ([Matthew 28:19](#)). Christian baptism symbolizes dying and rising with Jesus. It represents leaving the old life and starting a new one ([Romans 6:1–4; Colossians 2:12](#)). It also shows a Christian’s spiritual connection with Jesus and his Church ([Galatians 3:27](#)).

Baptism is the ceremony for entering the Christian community. Many see Christian baptism as the replacement for circumcision, which marked entry into Israel under the old covenant (see [Colossians 2:11–12](#)). Regardless of its link to Old Testament circumcision, baptism represents a changed will and “a clear conscience” that comes from God’s forgiveness ([1 Peter 3:21](#); compare [Deuteronomy 10:16; 30:6; Jeremiah 4:4; Romans 2:28–29; Philippians 3:3](#)).

Christian baptism is a ceremonial cleansing that symbolizes the forgiveness of sins ([Acts 2:38; 10:43; 13:38; 26:17–18](#)). It also represents receiving the Holy Spirit ([2:38; 9:17–18; 10:47–48; 11:15–17; 19:5–7; Luke 3:16](#)). Many believe baptism is an outward sign of the Spirit’s inner “seal,” which is a “pledge” of the eternal inheritance for God’s faithful people ([2 Corinthians 1:21–22; Ephesians 1:13–14; 4:30; Titus 3:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 3:6–16; 21:25; 28:19; Mark 1:4–9; 10:38–39; 11:30; 16:16; Luke 3:3–22; 7:29–30; 12:50; 20:4; John 1:25–36; 3:22–23, 26; 4:1–2; 10:40; Acts 1:5, 22; 2:38, 41; 8:12–13, 16–17, 36–38; 9:18; 10:37, 47–48; 11:16; 13:24; 16:15, 33; 18:8, 25; 19:1–7; 22:16; Romans 6:3–4; 1 Corinthians 1:13–17; 10:2; 12:13; 15:29; Galatians 3:27; Ephesians 4:5; Colossians 2:12; Hebrews 6:2; 1 Peter 3:21; 1 John 5:6](#)

Basic Laws

In Scripture, the one true God is the highest authority. God’s laws include both positive and negative commands. Two main laws summarize the positive commands:

- “You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength” ([Deuteronomy 6:5; Matthew 22:37; Mark 12:30; Luke 10:27](#)).
- “Love your neighbor as yourself” ([Leviticus 19:18; Matthew 19:19; Mark 12:31; Luke 10:27](#)).

We can see these two laws in the positive commands of the Ten Commandments ([Exodus 20:2–17; Deuteronomy 5:6–21](#)):

- “Remember the Sabbath day”
- “Honor your father and mother”

The negative commands make a boundary between good and evil. The first two of the Ten Commandments are key:

- “You shall have no other gods before Me” ([Exodus 20:3](#)).
- “You shall not make for yourself an idol in the form of anything ... You shall not bow down to them or worship them” ([Exodus 20:4-5](#)).

These forbidden actions go against the basic command to love God.

The prophets’ books show that God uses these laws to judge the Israelites’ actions. God also uses them to judge any ruler, group, or person at any time or place. Those who violate these main laws reject the one true God. This leads to divine judgment and disasters for sinners.

Sections for Additional Study

[Exodus 20:2-17](#); [Leviticus 19:18](#); [Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#); [6:5](#); [Jeremiah 2:7-13](#); [3:8-11](#); [5:1-9](#); [6:10-21](#); [7:16-29](#); [8:9-13](#); [11:6-14](#); [17:1-4](#); [22:1-9](#); [23:10-12](#); [34:8-20](#); [Matthew 19:19](#); [22:37](#); [Mark 12:30-31](#); [Luke 10:27](#); [1 Corinthians 13:13](#)

Beauty in Nature

At the end of God’s work of creation, God said that everything he made was “very good” ([Genesis 1:31](#)). Scripture often considers the beauty and wonder of God’s creation, especially in the psalms (see, for example, [Psalm 8:3-4](#); [Psalm 104:1-35](#)).

Nature and imagery from nature are important in the Song of Solomons (or Song of Songs). The man and woman often express their love in the countryside ([Song of Solomon 2:8-17](#); [4:12-5:1](#); [6:2-3](#), [11-12](#)). This is a place with pleasant smells and private spots. The garden, vineyard, and orchard create intimate and romantic settings. The mystery of nature gives them a simple, yet unfamiliar and exciting, scene for their love.

The couple uses many nature metaphors to describe each other’s physical features and their exciting effects. Their descriptions of each other lead them to use illustrations from God’s creation.

Nature directs people to the creator, showing evidence of his power, goodness, justice, and love (see [Psalm 19:1-4](#); [Romans 1:18-20](#)). God’s desire for redemption, restoration, and new creation is also evident in nature’s beauty. Examples include the changing seasons, plant growth, and the birth of children.

Sections for Additional Study

[Genesis 2:1-9](#); [Psalms 8:3-8](#); [19:1-6](#); [96:5-6](#); [Song of Solomon 2:8-17](#); [4:12-5:1](#); [6:2-3](#), [11-12](#); [7:10-13](#); [Matthew 6:26-30](#)

“Belief” in the Gospel of John

The theme of “belief” is central in John’s Gospel. John does not use the noun faith found often in the New Testament (for example, see [Matthew 8:8-10](#); [Mark 11:22](#); [Acts 20:21](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [3:27-31](#); [4:3-5](#); [Hebrews 11:1-39](#); [James 2:14-24](#); [1 Peter 1:5-7](#)). John prefers the verb form believe (“trust” or “be faithful”) to show that faith is not just a fixed belief, but is “alive” and requires action. In John’s Gospel, “believing” in Jesus is the mark of all true disciples.

In the Gospel of John, the verb translated as “believe” is often followed by the Greek preposition *eis*, which means “into.” This combination is unique in ancient Greek usage. For John, belief or faith is not just a status, it is an investment in Jesus. Faith means accepting who Jesus is and who he claims to be.

Faith also involves a commitment to let his invitation to trust in him change how a person lives. Faith is the work God wants from us ([John 6:29](#)). We demonstrate faith by following Jesus’ teachings, loving him, and obeying his commands ([John 8:31](#); [15:1-17](#); see [1 John 5:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [Isaiah 28:16](#); [Mark 1:15](#); [Mark 9:23-24](#); [John 1:12-13](#); [John 3:10-18](#); [John 5:24](#); [John 6:35-36](#); [John 7:38](#); [John 9:35-38](#); [John 11:25-27](#); [John 12:37](#); [John 20:25-31](#); [Acts 10:43](#); [Acts 13:39](#); [Romans 1:16](#); [Romans 10:9-10](#); [Hebrews 4:3](#)

Belonging to Christ

To many people today, the New Testament seems to present an extreme view of the Christian life. God calls Christians to give up their rights, endure suffering, and even face death for Jesus ([Mark 8:34-36](#)). They must turn away from worldly things that everyone pursues ([1 John 2:15-17](#)). They are to even despise their life in this world ([John 12:24-25](#)). Paul advises Christians to give up the usual desires for marriage and family and remain single for Jesus. Yet, this is only if they have that spiritual gift ([1 Corinthians 7:7](#)).

What is the reason for this extreme view of life? For Paul, it is the understanding that believers belong to Jesus, both body and soul. When Jesus died, he bought them for himself ([1 Corinthians 6:20](#)). They must no longer live only for themselves and their own desires ([2 Corinthians 5:14-15](#)). Having died to their personal

interests, he calls them to live fully for their Lord ([Romans 14:7-9](#)).

For true Christians, obeying Jesus is not a heavy burden. It is a way to show love and loyalty to the one who died for them. For Jesus' people, life is a joyful way to thank God for the grace shown through Jesus Christ. They are glad to dedicate their lives to serve the one who sacrificed everything for them (see [1 John 3:16](#)). By dying to their own desires, Christians allow Christ to live in and through them ([Galatians 2:19-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 9:26, 29; 32:9; 1 Kings 8:53; Psalms 2:8; 28:9; Ezekiel 18:4; Mark 8:34-36; 12:30; Romans 14:7-9; 1 Corinthians 6:19-20; 7:20-24; 7:32-35; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15; Galatians 2:19-20; 1 Peter 2:9-10](#)

Biblical Law

Biblical law is more than lists of rules. It is a system of what God expects about belief and behavior. If people follow it faithfully, they will receive God's greatest blessings. Keeping the law is essential for life ([Deuteronomy 4:1](#); see also [5:32-33; 8:1; 16:20](#)).

Israel's journey out of Egypt freed them to serve God. God rescued Israel "by a strong hand and an outstretched arm, and by great terrors" ([Deuteronomy 4:34](#)). This was not because Israel deserved it. But it was because God is gracious and keeps his promises to Abraham. The rescue from Egypt was not only to free the Israelites from hard labor ([Exodus 1:11-22; 5:4-23](#)). But it was also to make a covenant (special agreement) with them.

This covenant did not make the Israelites God's people. They already were his people (see [Exodus 4:22-23](#)). Obedience was not a requirement before the covenant. Instead, it was the right response to the covenant. It gave Israel the duty to serve God as "a kingdom of priests and a holy nation" ([Exodus 19:4-6](#)). God gave the law to guide Israel as a nation so that God's people would display his unfailing love and faithfulness.

The covenant promised the people of Israel a good and meaningful life if they followed the law. The covenant document includes broad principles, patterns, and standards. God's instructions are best known in the Ten Commandments ([Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#)). This is shown most briefly in the Jewish prayer called the Shema (a Hebrew word meaning "hear"). This prayer is found in [Deuteronomy 6:4-5](#). All other laws of God interpret and apply these main principles.

The life that came from following the law was not eternal life as described in the New Testament. God promised that if the Israelites obeyed the covenant, the nation would enjoy long and successful days in the promised land ([Deuteronomy 4:1; 5:16, 33](#)). Jesus also urged his disciples to follow the Ten Commandments and the demands of the Shema ([Matthew 22:37-40](#)). This was not to gain eternal life but to show their commitment to him (compare [Matthew 5:17-19; John 14:15-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 19:4-6; Leviticus 18:5; Deuteronomy 4:1-2; 5:6-21, 32-33; 6:1-9; 8:1; 30:1-20; Matthew 5:17-48; 22:36-40; John 14:15-21; Romans 3:19-24; 7:1-12; 1 Corinthians 9:20-21; Galatians 3:1-22; 5:14; Hebrews 7:18-19; 10:1](#)

Biblical Marriage

The story of creation portrays God as present with humanity's first union, set within the sacred space of the garden ([Genesis 2:18-25](#)). Biblical marriage is a binding covenant (special agreement) before God. Violating that covenant, such as through adultery, is a sin against both people and God. God is the divine witness who guarantees the marriage covenant (see [Malachi 2:10-16](#); compare [Genesis 39:6-9; Jeremiah 3:1; 1 Corinthians 6:9-10; Hebrews 13:4](#)). Although marriage is only between two people, it is not private. It is publically and legally declared, with community recognition, witnesses, and accountability (see [Leviticus 20:10-12; Deuteronomy 22:22; Jeremiah 29:20-23](#)).

Marriage is a metaphor for the LORD's relationship with his people (see [Exodus 19:3-6; 20:2-6; 34:14; Isaiah 54:5; Ezekiel 16; Hosea 2:19-20](#)). It is first with Israel and then with the church (see [2 Corinthians 11:2; Ephesians 5:21-33](#)). A marriage symbolizes something greater. God's people (Christ's "bride") await Christ's return (the "groom"). Married Christians should live in unity and dignity as they look forward to "the marriage of the Lamb" ([Revelation 19:6-9](#)). Christ will live forever with his faithful people in glory ([Revelation 19:7; 21:2, 9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:18-25; 24:65-67; Psalm 45:8-15; Isaiah 54:5; Hosea 2:19-20; Malachi 2:10-16; 1 Corinthians 7:1-40; 2 Corinthians 6:14-16; Ephesians 5:21-33; Hebrews 13:4; 1 Peter 3:1-7](#)

The Birth of Christ

The stories of the birth of Jesus show contrasts show a clear contrast between humble circumstances and divine importance ([Matthew 1:18-2:12](#); [Luke 2:1-20](#)).

On one side, we see the humble nature of his birth. A poor couple travels to Bethlehem, the home of their ancestors. They go to register for a census (a government count of all the people living in a country or region) ordered by the Roman Empire, which ruled over their land at that time. Their journey from Galilee to Bethlehem was long and difficult. When they arrived, they could not find any place to stay. They had to use a place where animals were kept.

The whole situation showed poverty, rejection, and lack of attention from others. When Jesus was born, the news was not sent to important kings or wealthy people. Instead, the announcement went to simple shepherds who were watching their sheep in a field nearby.

Yet beside this humble setting is a message of amazing power and greatness. The baby placed in a feeding trough (manger) is the Messiah, the long-awaited descendant of King David. He will rule victoriously over the people of Israel, and his kingdom will never end.

He is the one all the prophets spoke about. All of history had been pointing forward to its most important moment in him. A group of wise men from eastern countries traveled to honor him. And an army of powerful angels came from heaven to announce his birth.

These contrasts give us a first look at what will come later. In Jesus, the God of Israel and Lord of all the earth has come to visit and save his people. God comes down from heaven to meet people in their everyday lives and circumstances. Throughout the Gospels, Jesus shows special concern for the humble, the poor, the rejected, and sinners. He comes to save them because they recognize their need for him. They receive the message of salvation with joy and happiness.

The contrast between humility and greatness also connects to Jesus' mission. Evil people reject him and kill him. Yet, God proves Jesus right at his resurrection and raises Jesus to his "right hand."

There at his throne, he rules as Lord and Messiah. From there, he sends the Spirit of God to lead and guide his church. Through his life, death, resurrection, and rise to glory, Jesus offers forgiveness of sins. He gives eternal life to all who respond to him with a faithful life.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 1:18-2:12](#); [Luke 2:1-20](#)

Blessing

Before the patriarch Jacob died, he blessed each of his sons and Joseph's sons ([Genesis 49:1-28](#); [48:3-20](#)). This was also how his father Isaac had blessed him ([27:27-29](#)). A blessing gives, improves, and enriches life, while a curse harms it ([Leviticus 26:14-39](#)). A benefactor (a person who gives help) gives a blessing publicly, providing power for prosperity and success.

Blessings are essential in covenant relationships. This is because they guide and motivate people to follow the covenant's rules ([Leviticus 26:3-13](#)). Obedience leads to blessings, while rebellion results in a curse (see [Deuteronomy 28](#)).

The first area of blessing is creation. God, as creator, gives blessings to animals and humans ([Genesis 1:22](#); [1:28](#); see [Psalms 104](#); [128:3-4](#)). God also uses humans also to give divine blessings. God chose Abraham to bless the nations ([Genesis 12:2-3](#)). God supports and purifies the family, government, and religion through blessings ([27:27-29](#); [14:19](#); [1 Kings 8:14](#), [52](#), [66](#); [Leviticus 9:22](#)). Israel's priests passed on God's blessing to Israel ([Numbers 6:24-26](#); [Deuteronomy 10:8](#)).

Old Testament blessings have three main aspects:

1. A greater group gives them to a lesser one ([Genesis 32:26](#); [Hebrews 7:6-7](#)).
2. They show favor, leading to well-being and success ([Deuteronomy 28:3-7](#)).
3. They recognize that all power and blessings come from the creator. God's love is the source of all blessings ([Deuteronomy 7:7-8](#), [12-15](#)).

God's blessings in the Old Testament are very different from those in ancient pagan religions. In pagan religions, people believed that wealth and fertility in family, animals, and crops came through "sympathetic" magical ceremonies (special religious rituals) at their worship places. These ceremonies intended to influence the gods to maintain the cycle of life. In the Old Testament, all life, fertility, and blessings came from God's command, as he is the only true and living God.

In the New Testament, blessings focus more on spiritual matters than material ones. They shift from the Israelite nation to the church and from temporary to eternal ([Matthew 6:25](#); [Ephesians 1:3](#); [1 Peter 3:9](#)). Through his death, Jesus took on the consequences of sin's curse ([Galatians 3:13](#)). He established God's kingdom ([Matthew 3:2](#); [5:3-20](#); [John 3:3-5](#)). He gave forgiveness of sin to its citizens ([Romans 4:6-25](#)). Now,

God calls Christians to bless the world ([Luke 6:27–28](#); [Romans 12:14](#); see also [Isaiah 19:24](#); [Zechariah 8:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:22, 28; 9:26–27; 12:2–3; 14:19–20; 24:59–60; 27:1–41; 28:1–4; 32:24–30; 46:1–50:26; Leviticus 26:3–13; Numbers 6:22–27; Deuteronomy 7:12–15; 10:8; 28:1–14; 33:1–29; 1 Samuel 2:20–21; Psalm 128:1–6; Matthew 5:3–12; Luke 6:27–28; Romans 12:14; Galatians 3:13–14; Ephesians 1:3; Hebrews 7:6–7; 1 Peter 3:9](#)

The Blessings of Jesus

The Beatitudes are the blessings Jesus gave to his followers. They get their name from the word *beati* (which means blessed) in the Latin translation of the Bible (the Vulgate). No single word can fully express what Jesus means here. He describes God’s special favor toward his people, both physically and spiritually, and the outcomes of living in that favor.

The Beatitudes describe how a follower of Jesus should live and behave. Jesus invites people to follow him as he shares the message of the kingdom with Israel (see also [Matthew 11:6; 13:16; 16:17; 24:46](#)). Those who Jesus blesses have repented from their sins in response to the kingdom’s message ([Matthew 4:17–22](#)). The Beatitudes relate to [Isaiah 61:1–3](#). The Holy Spirit gives power and leads people to share the good news about Jesus. The Holy Spirit blesses the poor, the humble, and the righteous.

In the Bible, the word “blessed” suggests:

- These blessings come from God and show his approval (see [Matthew 25:34](#)).
- The blessings show God’s promises coming true (see [Matthew 11:6; 13:16; 16:17](#)).
- The blessings change things in surprising ways, making life better for those who trust God (see [Luke 1:1–2:52; 6:20–26](#)).
- To receive these blessings, people need to obey God (see [Psalms 1:1, 3–6; 106:3; 112:1–2; 119:1–2; Proverbs 8:32; Isaiah 56:2](#)).

These blessings began when Jesus the Messiah came to earth. Christians can be confident that they will enjoy these blessings fully and forever.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 1:1–3; 106:3; 112:1–2; 119:1–2; Isaiah 56:1–2; Matthew 5:3–12; 11:6; 13:16; 16:17; 24:46; 25:34; Luke 6:20–26](#)

Bread from Heaven

When the Israelites left Egypt and entered the wilderness, God provided manna. Manna was a substance like bread that God gave them to eat ([Exodus 16](#)). The LORD gave them enough food for their daily needs (see [Nehemiah 9:20–21](#)). This “bread from heaven” demonstrated God’s love and showed his special care for Israel in the wilderness (see [Deuteronomy 8:3, 16; Psalms 78:24; 105:40](#); compare [Revelation 2:17](#)).

Manna was real food, but some passages use it symbolically. It represents a spiritual relationship with God. It is a sign of God’s miraculous provision for his people (see [1 Corinthians 10:3–4](#)). At the same time, manna relates to Israel’s complaints against God and their lack of trust in his provision ([Numbers 11:1–15](#); see [1 Corinthians 10:5](#)).

Jesus miraculously fed about 5,000 men near the Sea of Galilee, in addition to women and children. Then he taught in the synagogue at Capernaum about the “bread of life” ([John 6:22–59](#)). He called himself the “true bread from heaven” and “the bread of life” ([John 6:32–35](#)). He even connected eternal life with the need to eat “My flesh and drink My blood” ([John 6:50–58](#)). Manna provided food in the wilderness. But Jesus is the true bread from God, who offers spiritual food and strength. Israel’s need for food humbled them in the wilderness ([Deuteronomy 8:3](#)). Now, followers of Jesus must humble themselves and receive the fullness of his life by faith ([John 6:35–40, 47–51, 63–64](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 16:1–36; Numbers 11:1–15; Deuteronomy 8:3, 16; Joshua 5:10–12; Nehemiah 9:20–21; Psalms 78:24; 105:40; John 6:1–15, 22–64; 1 Corinthians 10:3–5; Revelation 2:17](#)

Bribery and Gifts

The Bible provides clear teachings about bribes (payments given to unfairly influence decisions) and gifts (offerings given to show respect or maintain relationships). Bribes are strongly condemned because they corrupt justice and lead to unfair treatment. For example, [Exodus 23:8](#) commands, “Do not accept a bribe, for a bribe blinds those who see and twists the words of the righteous” (see also [Deuteronomy 16:19](#)).

The book of Proverbs includes several observations about how bribes and gifts operate in society. Some verses describe the effectiveness of bribes in achieving results ([Proverbs 17:8; 18:16](#)). These verses describe human behavior but do not endorse bribery.

Other verses in Proverbs explicitly show that bribery is wrong, especially when it corrupts justice ([Proverbs 15:27](#); [17:23](#)).

The Bible distinguishes between bribes and legitimate gifts. Bribes are secret payments meant to gain unfair advantages or pervert justice. Gifts, however, are often given openly to show respect, maintain relationships, or follow cultural customs of hospitality. For example, in [Genesis 32:20](#), Jacob sends gifts to Esau to mend their relationship. Similarly, [1 Samuel 10:27](#) describes people bringing gifts to honor Saul as their new king.

While the Bible recognizes the cultural role of gifts, it consistently condemns bribery, emphasizing justice, fairness, and integrity.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:8](#); [Deuteronomy 10:17](#); [16:19](#); [1 Samuel 8:1-3](#); [Proverbs 17:8](#), [23](#); [18:16](#); [29:4](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:7](#); [Isaiah 1:23](#); [33:14-16](#); [Amos 5:12](#); [Micah 3:9-12](#); [7:3](#); [Matthew 28:11-15](#)

The Broken Covenant

After God rescued the Israelites from Egypt, he made a special agreement (called a covenant) with them (see [Exodus 20-24](#)). In this covenant, God gave them the Ten Commandments and other laws. The people promised to follow these laws, and God promised to bless them if they did. But the Israelites broke the terms of the covenant.

A central issue in God's relationship with Israel was whether the covenant made at Mount Sinai was still valid after the people had broken it. In ancient Near Eastern politics, covenants were common. When one of the partners in a covenant broke the terms of the agreement, the result was usually war.

The covenant was special because God was one of the partners. It followed the pattern of non-religious covenants and required both God and Israel to confirm the agreement with oaths promising to be faithful ([Exodus 24:1-11](#); [Deuteronomy 29-30](#); [Joshua 8:30-35](#); [24:1-28](#)).

God always remained faithful to his covenant, but the Israelites continued to break it. Canaanite worship of many gods tempted them away from the Lord. They worshipped idols and engaged in immoral sexual ceremonies. They treated the poor and needy badly and ignored God's rules for righteousness.

For centuries, the Israelites either worshiped God (Yahweh) or Canaanite gods. Whenever they repented and obeyed God, he mercifully accepted them back into the covenant relationship. Yet, by the mid-700s

BC, the Israelites of the northern kingdom of Israel had become stubbornly committed to idol worship. So God allowed the Assyrians to destroy the kingdom and take many people into captivity.

The prophet Jeremiah's ministry was over one hundred years later. Now Judah was committing idolatry. Jeremiah compared this situation to a marriage divorce, similar to Hosea's earlier story about Israel ([Jeremiah 2-3](#); compare [Hosea 1-2](#)). The Scriptures compare Israel's relationship with God to a marriage where the bride committed adultery.

God accused his people of breaking the marriage bond and behaving like a prostitute ([Jeremiah 3:1](#)). He warned them to repent or encounter destruction. God could no longer say of the Israelites, "I will be their God, and they will be My people" (see [Jeremiah 31:33](#); see also [Exodus 6:7](#); [Hosea 1:9](#)).

Breaking the covenant led to the northern kingdom's destruction and later the destruction of the kingdom of Judah. Babylon destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. This punishment deeply pained God. The ever-merciful God promised a new covenant to replace the Sinai covenant that Israel had broken ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:7](#); [Jeremiah 2:1-3](#); [10:4](#); [22:8-9](#); [31:31-34](#); [Ezekiel 16:1-63](#); [Hosea 2:2-13](#); [3:1](#); [4:1-5](#); [15](#)

The Bronze Snake

[Numbers 21:4-9](#) describes an event where the Israelites complained against God and Moses. They were unhappy about the food and water and said, "We detest this wretched food!" ([21:5](#)). In response, the Lord sent poisonous snakes that bit and killed many people (see [Deuteronomy 8:15](#)). Realizing their mistake, the Israelites asked Moses to pray for the removal of the snakes. God told Moses to make a bronze snake. Anyone bitten could look at it and God would heal them ([Numbers 21:8](#)).

This was not a typical medical treatment. The healing came from God and required faith to look at the bronze snake and trust in God's healing power. The snake bites were a result of God's punishment. But he also provided a way for their salvation through his mercy (see [Wisdom of Solomon 16:5-7](#)).

When Hezekiah became king of Judah in 715 BC, the Israelites started using Moses' bronze serpent as an idol (see [2 Kings 18:1-4](#)). They probably kept the image to remember God's power. This was similar to other holy things from the wilderness period (see [Deuteronomy 10:5](#); [Hebrews 9:4-5](#)). Yet, they began

worshipping it as another god. So they had to destroy it like other pagan worship items and pillars. Such idolatry threatens the worship of the one true God (compare [Exodus 32](#)).

Jesus mentioned the bronze snake incident to prophesy how he would die. He would “be lifted up” on the cross like Moses lifted the snake on a pole ([John 3:14–15](#); see also [8:28](#); [12:32–33](#)). The metal snake image acted as a cure for snake bites. Similarly, those who look to Christ’s cross and accept Jesus’ sacrifice receive an eternal promise ([John 3:14–16](#)).

The Lord sent snakes to punish Israel for complaining about the manna in the wilderness ([Numbers 21:4–9](#)). Jesus called himself “the true bread from heaven,” the spiritual manna that gives eternal life to his people ([John 6:32–40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 21:4–9](#); [2 Kings 18:1–4](#); [John 3:14–15](#); [6:32–40](#); [8:28](#); [12:30–34](#)

By Faith

Faith is a key theme in Scripture, but many misunderstand it. Some think faith means any kind of spirituality, like saying someone is a “person of faith.” Others think it means a strong belief that good things will happen, like a way to become healthy and wealthy. Some think faith means believing without evidence. None of these ideas represent biblical faith.

[Hebrews 11](#), one of the most loved passages of Scripture, offers a detailed essay on what it means to live “by faith.” It describes faith as taking confident action based on what God has revealed. Throughout the chapter, examples show faith in different life situations. What faith produces can vary.

“By faith” some people find rescue, achieve success, and receive some of God’s promises during their lives. “By faith” others face mockery, beatings, torture, imprisonment, and death. Faith might have a reward sooner or later. Faithful people hope for rewards because they trust that God is good and true to his promises.

What does it mean to live “by faith?” It means that in different situations, we act on our belief that God “exists and that He rewards those who earnestly seek Him” ([Hebrews 11:6](#)). People who live by faith take confident actions based on what God has shown about his character, intending to do his will in everything.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [2 Chronicles 20:20](#); [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Matthew 9:29](#); [21:21](#); [Luke 8:50](#); [John 3:16](#), [36](#); [5:24](#); [11:25](#); [12:46](#); [20:30–31](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [10:9](#), [17](#); [Galatians 3:6](#); [5:6](#); [1 Timothy 1:19](#); [6:12](#); [Hebrews 10:22](#), [38](#); [11:1–40](#); [James 1:5–6](#); [2:14–26](#); [1 John 3:23](#); [5:4](#)